

05 - Personal Layer and My Map

Personal Layer — “My Map,” Forking, and Sharing

Purpose: The original spec (docs/01) promises users they can save their own connections as a personal layer (“my map”). This document defines how that personal layer works — how it’s stored, how it relates to the canonical map, and how users can share or fork their maps.

Design principle

The canonical Source Map (curated by the project) is the **base layer**. Every user gets their own **overlay** that lives on top of it. Overlays can:

- Add new connection lines between existing nodes
- Add notes to existing nodes
- Highlight subsets of nodes the user finds important
- Add new nodes (proposed; flagged as user-contributed)
- Hide nodes the user wants out of view
- Be exported, shared, and forked

Crucially: the user’s overlay never alters the base layer. The base map is a stable reference shared by everyone. The overlay is the user’s interpretation written on top of it.

Three views of the same map

The UI surfaces three view modes (per docs/01 section 4) and the personal layer interacts with each:

View mode	What it shows	Personal layer behavior
Canonical	Base map only, project-curated	Overlay is hidden; user sees the same map as everyone else
My Map	Base map + user's overlay	All user-drawn connections, notes, highlights, hidden nodes applied
Scholarly	Base map + scholarly caveats	Independent of personal layer; can be combined with My Map

The “My Map” toggle is the entry point to the personal layer. Default behavior on first session: a clean overlay with no edits.

What a user can add to their overlay

1. Custom connection lines

The signature interaction. The user drags from one node to another and records *why* they see a parallel. Each user-drawn line has its own schema (see [docs/06](#) for the connection-evidence detail):

```
{
  "id": "user-conn-9f3a",
  "from_node": "enki",
  "to_node": "prometheus",
  "user_id": "user_xyz",
  "evidence_types": ["structural-function-match", "narrative-pattern-match"],
  "note": "Both fashioned humanity and defied the senior council to give us
fire/wisdom.",
  "created_at": "2026-05-15T19:00:00Z",
  "visibility": "private"
}
```

2. Node annotations

Personal notes attached to existing nodes. Markdown-supported. Visible only to the user unless explicitly shared.

```

{
  "id": "user-note-1c2d",
  "node_id": "sophia",
  "user_id": "user_xyz",
  "body": "Reading Sophia as the same figure as the Holy Spirit in feminine
readings cracked something open. Returning to this.",
  "created_at": "2026-05-15T19:05:00Z",
  "visibility": "private"
}

```

3. Highlights and tags

Custom colored highlights or tags applied to nodes, so a user can color-code their own thematic groupings.

```

{
  "id": "user-tag-set-3",
  "user_id": "user_xyz",
  "tag_name": "Light-bringers I want to study",
  "color": "#ffb547",
  "node_ids": ["sophia", "prometheus", "enki", "thoth", "christ-aeon", "khidr"]
}

```

4. Hidden nodes

The user can hide nodes from their personal view without affecting the base map.

```

{
  "user_id": "user_xyz",
  "hidden_node_ids": ["modern-syncretic-channeled-source-X"]
}

```

5. User-proposed nodes

A user can add a figure they think should be in the database. These are flagged as user-contributed and only appear in that user's overlay until reviewed for inclusion in the canonical map.

```

{
  "id": "user-node-tiamat",
  "primary_name": "Tiamat",
  "tradition": "Mesopotamian (older Sumero-Akkadian layer)",
  "tier": "cross-tier",
  "user_id": "user_xyz",
  "status": "user-contributed-pending-review",
  "essence": "Primordial saltwater chaos-mother slain by Marduk to fashion the
cosmos from her corpse. Read as the suppressed feminine ground in some feminist
Gnostic readings.",
  "function_tags": ["primordial-feminine", "slain-by-demiurge", "matter-as-
mother"],
  "parallel_node_ids_proposed": ["sophia", "shakti", "nuit"]
}

```

When the user shares a map containing user-proposed nodes, the recipient sees them clearly marked as user-contributed.

Forking

A user can **fork** another user's published map. Forking is the act of taking someone else's overlay and making it the starting point for one's own.

When User B forks User A's map:

1. A copy of User A's overlay is created and attached to User B's account.
2. The copy retains attribution: "Forked from User A's *Light-Bringers Working Map*, May 2026."
3. User B can then add, remove, or modify connections and notes freely. None of their changes affect User A's original.
4. Forks can be forked. The lineage is preserved as a chain.

Forking is the mechanism by which interpretive lineages form within the app. A teacher publishes their map; students fork it; students publish their own versions; over time, a tree of related interpretive maps grows.

Fork attribution

Each overlay tracks its lineage:

```
{
  "overlay_id": "overlay_xyz",
  "user_id": "user_xyz",
  "title": "My working map, after reading Pagels",
  "forked_from": "overlay_abc",
  "forked_from_user": "user_abc",
  "forked_from_title": "Pagels-inspired Gnostic emphasis",
  "fork_depth": 2,
  "created_at": "2026-05-15T20:00:00Z"
}
```

Sharing

Three sharing modes:

1. Private (default)

The overlay is visible only to the user. No one else can view, fork, or comment.

2. Unlisted link

The user generates a shareable URL. Anyone with the link can view the overlay but not modify it. The link can be revoked.

Use case: sharing one's working map with a specific friend or teacher.

3. Published

The user publishes the overlay to a public directory. Other users can browse, view, and fork. The publisher can choose whether to allow comments on published maps.

When published, the overlay receives:

- A public URL
- A title and description chosen by the user
- A creator handle (anonymized if the user prefers)
- A tag set (e.g., "Gnostic-emphasis," "Feminine-divine focus," "Hindu-Christian parallels")
- A fork count and a view count

Published map metadata schema

```
{
  "overlay_id": "overlay_xyz",
  "title": "The Wisdom-Mother Across Traditions",
  "description": "An overlay foregrounding Sophia, Shekhinah, Shakti, Isis,
Ma'at, and Prajnaparamita as one continuous figure.",
  "creator_handle": "soul_cartographer",
  "tags": ["feminine-divine", "Sophia", "cross-tradition"],
  "published_at": "2026-05-15T21:00:00Z",
  "view_count": 0,
  "fork_count": 0,
  "license": "CC-BY-SA-4.0",
  "visibility": "published"
}
```

Map export and import

Every overlay can be exported as a single JSON file containing all connections, notes, tags, hidden nodes, and user-proposed nodes. The file is portable: a user can back it up, edit it in a text editor, transfer between accounts, or import another user's exported map directly.

Export schema (top level)

```
{
  "schema_version": "1.0",
  "exported_at": "2026-05-15T22:00:00Z",
  "overlay": {
    "id": "overlay_xyz",
    "title": "My working map",
    "description": "...",
    "creator_handle": "user_xyz",
    "forked_from": null,
    "fork_depth": 0
  },
  "connections": [],
  "annotations": [],
  "tag_sets": [],
  "hidden_node_ids": [],
  "user_proposed_nodes": []
}
```

Each array above contains objects in the corresponding schemas defined earlier in this document:

`connections` uses the user-drawn connection schema, `annotations` uses the user-note schema, `tag_sets` uses the user-tag-set schema, and `user_proposed_nodes` uses the user-proposed-node schema.

This is also the format used for forking under the hood — a fork is just an internal import-with-attribution.

Comments on published maps

Optional feature, opt-in per publisher. Comments attach to:

- The whole map (general feedback)
- A specific user-drawn connection (debate the parallel)
- A specific node annotation (respond to the note)

Comments inherit the same proponent-voice-by-default editorial direction. Scholarly caveats apply equally to comments — a commenter pushing back on a parallel can cite scholarly mode if they want academic backing.

Moderation and curation

User-proposed nodes that the project curators accept get promoted into the canonical map. The contributor is credited (with their consent) in the node's metadata as a contributor.

Published maps that violate the project's editorial principles (gratuitous attack on living traditions, hate-speech disguised as commentary, etc.) are subject to moderation. The default stance is permissive — comparative esotericism inherently includes contested claims — but published maps are subject to community guidelines.

Why the personal layer matters

The framework's core promise (per docs/01's framing text) is that the user can build their own map of the divine. Without the personal layer, the Source Map is a finished encyclopedia. With it, the Source Map becomes a tool for the user's own work — a working surface on which their interpretation can be drawn, refined, shared, contested, and forked.

The personal layer is what turns a structural atlas into a personal practice.